D Minor

Scale Practice Worksheet · One flat, B♭ · Relative minor of F major · 4 octaves

Relative vs. parallel keys

D minor is the relative minor of F major. Both keys share the same key signature — one flat, B♭. A relative key shares the key signature; a parallel key shares the root. The parallel minor of D major is D minor; the parallel major of F major is F minor. Knowing the difference matters when reading and analyzing music.

SCALES

01 Scale, Natural Minor

Play D natural minor up and down across 4 octaves: **D – E – F – G – A – B ♭ – C – D**. The natural minor uses the same notes as F major starting from D.

TIP
This is the foundation. The harmonic and melodic forms below alter specific degrees — practice the natural form first to feel the unaltered shape under the hand.

02 Harmonic Minor

Raise the 7th degree: C becomes C♯. Scale: **D – E – F – G – A – B ♭ – C♯ – D**. The raised 7th gives the scale its characteristic minor sound and creates a strong leading tone into the tonic.

03 Melodic Minor

Ascending, raise both the 6th and 7th degrees: B♭ becomes B♮, C becomes C♯. Ascending scale: **D – E – F – G – A – B – C♯ – D**.

Descending, return to the natural form: **D – C – B ♭ – A – G – F – E – D**.

TIP
The asymmetry between ascending and descending is what makes the melodic minor uniquely valuable for training.

04 Scale in Thirds

Play the scale in intervals of a third — two notes a third apart, played together or in succession.

05 Scale in Tenths

Play the scale in tenths between the hands. A tenth feels like a third, only an octave higher — the right hand plays one octave above the third position.

06 Scale in Sixths

Play the scale in sixths between the hands. The right hand starts on D; the left hand starts a sixth below, on F. From there, both hands move together through the scale.

ARPEGGIOS & CHORDS — TONIC, D MINOR

07 Tonic Long Arpeggio

Play the tonic chord as a long arpeggio across the keyboard, ascending and descending. Practice all three inversions:

Root position **D – F – A – D**

1st inversion **F – A – D – F**

2nd inversion **A – D – F – A**

Fingering, root position:

RH: `1-2-3-1-2-3-1-2-3-1-2-3-5`

LH: `5-4-2-1-4-2-1-4-2-1-4-2-1`

> TIP
> Locate the harmonic function under the hand before playing. Recognizing tonic shape across inversions is the goal — not memorizing notes one at a time.

ARPEGGIOS & CHORDS — DOMINANT, A MAJOR

08 Dominant Chord and Arpeggio

The dominant is built on the 5th degree of the scale: A. The dominant chord in D minor is A major. The C♯ comes from the harmonic minor scale.

Play each inversion as a solid chord with all notes struck together, and as a long arpeggio across the keyboard:

Root position **A – C♯ – E – A**

1st inversion **C♯ – E – A – C♯**

2nd inversion **E – A – C♯ – E**

ARPEGGIOS & CHORDS — SUBDOMINANT, G MINOR

09 Subdominant Chord and Arpeggio

The subdominant is built on the 4th degree of the scale: G. The subdominant chord in D minor is G minor.

Play each inversion as a solid chord and as a long arpeggio across the keyboard:

Root position **G – B♭ – D – G**

1st inversion **B♭ – D – G – B♭**

2nd inversion **D – G – B♭ – D**

> TIP
> Most music — popular and classical — circles around three basic harmonic functions: tonic, dominant, subdominant. Recognizing them at the keyboard makes pieces easier to learn and memorize.

VARIATIONS

Contrary Motion

Any scale or arpeggio exercise can be played in contrary motion — one hand ascending while the other descends simultaneously. Harder than parallel motion and excellent brain training.

Accent & Rhythmic Variations

Apply to any scale or arpeggio exercise for fluidity and evenness:

a — Accent every note: extra weight on each individual note.

b — Accent every second note: grouped, rolling feel.

c — Triplet groupings: organize the scale in groups of three.

d — Groups of four: organize the scale in groups of four.

e — Prolong one note per group: hold the 2nd or 3rd note slightly longer to build control.

f — Groups of seven: the scale normally falls in groups of eight, so grouping in sevens shifts the accent and exposes unevenness.

Staccato

Any scale exercise can be played staccato — lift from each key rather than connecting the notes. Treat it as a separate pass, not a replacement for legato practice.

GENERAL PRACTICE PRINCIPLES

- Locate harmonic functions — tonic, dominant, subdominant — under the hand before playing through them
- Practice scales in multiple intervals: octaves, thirds, sixths, tenths
- Memorize music in harmonic blocks, not note by note — thinking in chord shapes makes pieces easier to learn and retain
- Apply scales knowledge directly to repertoire: identify the tonic, dominant, subdominant, and any altered chords in the music being learned
- Recognize chord shapes across all inversions, not just root position
- Practice the harmonic and melodic forms, not just the natural minor — the altered tones are where the technical value lives
- Practice each hand separately before combining